

CREDIT REPORTING FOR LANDLORDS · REFERENCE

The RentBureau Advantage

The single biggest reason to place a move-out balance instead of writing it off

Most landlords can chase a departed tenant with letters and calls. What they cannot do — and what changes the entire economics of post-eviction recovery — is report that unpaid balance to the database the tenant's next landlord will actually see. That database is Experian RentBureau, and furnishing to it is the differentiator that turns a "never-going-to-pay" balance into a paid one.

Executive summary

- RentBureau is the largest rental-payment database — 9M+ residents, with 3,000+ apartment communities reporting every 24 hours.
- It feeds the tenant-screening report the next landlord pulls, so an unpaid balance follows the tenant to their next application.
- Only FCRA-approved furnishers can report to it — most landlords cannot do this themselves. SWRS does, at no additional charge, as part of standard placement.
- Combined with Equifax and Experian reporting (a 50–100+ point potential score impact, up to seven years), it is the strongest lawful motivator to pay.

1. What RentBureau is, and why it is the landlord's differentiator

Experian RentBureau is the largest and most widely used database of rental-payment history in the United States. It aggregates lease and payment data from more than 3,000 apartment communities, updated every 24 hours, covering nine million-plus residents — and that data flows into the tenant-screening reports and Experian consumer files other operators rely on when deciding whom to approve for a lease. A traditional credit tradeline affects a former tenant's general credit; a RentBureau entry does something more targeted and more powerful for a property owner, surfacing the unpaid balance precisely where it hurts a delinquent renter most — on the screening report the next apartment community pulls before approving them. It follows the tenant, creating direct pressure to resolve the balance in order to move; and because reporting to RentBureau requires being an FCRA-approved data furnisher meeting its data and compliance standards, most owners and managers cannot do it themselves. Southwest Recovery, as an approved furnisher, reports qualifying placed accounts to RentBureau at no additional charge as part of standard contingency placement.

2. The full reporting picture, and why it gets balances paid

RentBureau is one part of a coordinated approach. On qualifying accounts, Southwest Recovery reports to Equifax and Experian — the general consumer files that affect loans, cards and housing decisions — and to Experian RentBureau, the rental-specific screening data the next landlord sees. Reported correctly, an unpaid-rent balance can lower a former tenant's score by 50 to 100 points or more and remain on file for up to seven years. (We report to Equifax and Experian plus RentBureau — not to a "third bureau" — and RentBureau is the rental-specific value-add a general tradeline cannot replicate.) It works because it changes the tenant's incentives at exactly the moment they need something from the system: a departed tenant may ignore letters for months, until they try to lease their next apartment and discover the balance standing between them and approval. That is when a long-dormant account converts to a negotiated payoff. The reporting is not a threat — it is an accurate, compliant record — and it is remarkably effective.

3. Reporting done correctly

Because residential tenant debt is consumer debt, reporting follows the FDCPA and Regulation F sequence: a validation notice to the consumer with the debt amount, creditor and their rights; a 30-day dispute window honored before the balance is furnished; and accurate, verifiable furnishing in which only legitimate, documented balances are reported and disputes are investigated and corrected. The tradeline can remain up to seven years and is updated or removed when the balance is resolved. This is precisely why an FCRA-approved furnisher matters: accurate, compliant reporting is what makes the leverage lawful and durable — and protects the owner from the liability that sloppy self-reporting would create.

Why it works when letters don't

Tenant screening is now near-universal in professional property management, and that is exactly what gives RentBureau its leverage. When a former tenant applies for their next apartment, the prospective landlord pulls a screening report — and a reported unpaid balance surfaces on it, often as the reason an application is declined or a larger deposit is demanded. A departed tenant who ignored months of letters suddenly has a concrete, immediate reason to resolve the balance: they cannot move on until they do. That is why a compliant RentBureau entry converts dormant accounts that traditional dunning never would.

The same mechanism is why accuracy and compliance are non-negotiable. Only legitimate, fully documented balances are furnished; the consumer's validation and 30-day dispute rights are honored first; disputes are investigated and corrected; and the entry is updated or removed the moment the balance is resolved. Done that way, the leverage is durable and lawful — and it protects the property owner rather than exposing them.

What qualifies, and how fast it moves

Not every balance is reported, and that is by design. A qualifying account is one that is legitimate, documented, and past the validation and dispute window — typically an undisputed move-out balance supported by the lease and itemized ledger. Once placed, the sequence is straightforward: we validate the debt and issue the consumer's notice, honor the 30-day dispute period, and then furnish qualifying accounts to Equifax, Experian and RentBureau. From that point the entry does its work quietly in the background, surfacing whenever the former tenant is screened for new housing.

The entry stays until the balance is resolved, and it is updated or removed promptly when the tenant pays or settles — which is both the compliant way to furnish and part of what makes it effective, because the tenant knows resolving the balance is what clears the obstacle. It is, in effect, a recovery mechanism that keeps working long after a traditional collection effort would have gone quiet.

How Southwest Recovery puts it to work

You place qualifying move-out balances through our secure portal with the ledger and lease documentation; we validate, honor the dispute window, and furnish qualifying accounts to Equifax, Experian and RentBureau as part of standard placement — at no additional charge and on pure contingency. Then dormant balances begin converting on their own schedule, as former tenants discover the entry when they apply for their next lease. It is the closest thing in post-eviction recovery to a balance that collects itself.

For a property owner, that is the whole case for placement over write-off: the same balance you were about to concede becomes an asset that follows the tenant and resolves itself when they next need housing — furnished for you, compliantly, at no additional charge.

About Southwest Recovery Services

Southwest Recovery Services is a property-management and multifamily recovery specialist working post-eviction and unpaid-rent balances on pure contingency since 2004 — with a strong Texas footprint of six offices (Addison HQ, Austin, Dallas, Houston, Midland, San Antonio) among twelve across seven states, and recovery reach nationwide. Over two decades we have placed more than \$975M in receivables, recovered over \$76M for clients, and worked 800,000+ accounts. We furnish qualifying accounts to Equifax and Experian, plus Experian RentBureau — the rental-specific value-add most landlords cannot report themselves — at no additional charge, and we work every account on pure contingency (\$0 upfront) under a documented, FDCPA/Reg F-compliant process as an ACA International member.

Make your balances impossible to ignore

Ask us how RentBureau furnishing works on your portfolio — it's included in standard contingency placement, at no additional charge.

Call (866) 551-4684 · sdietz@swrecovery.com · swrecovery.com

Provided for general informational purposes; not legal advice. Recovery figures are illustrative and vary by portfolio; statutes and court timelines vary by jurisdiction — confirm with counsel. Southwest Recovery Services does not collect consumer debt in California, Oregon or Washington.